We knew the US would impose sanctions if we went ahead with the contract. Since everything ISRO did was being closely watched by the US, we asked Glavkosmos to tie up with KELTEC (Kerala Hi-tech Industries Limited), a quasi-government entity under the Government of Kerala. But the US saw through this strategy. In May 1992, the US imposed sanctions on India and Russia for two years invoking Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR) provisions.

The next one year was spent devising ways and means to preserve the contract and make Russia honour it despite severe pressure from the US. Dunayev was cooperative, and we had many exchanges. I made multiple visits to Russia. Once or twice I accompanied U R Rao, a veteran of Russian pacts, to interior Russia where hundreds toiled away in snow-covered facilities to make some of the finest pieces of space engineering, and try to find answers to the secrets of the universe.

There were two distinct groups within the Russian space community—one who believed that Russia and India are ‘natural partners’ and the friendship should continue at any cost; the other who did not quite question the Russia-India camaraderie, but yielded to either American threats or favours.

Dunayev was the tallest technocrat who represented the former group. He prevailed upon Russian President Boris Yeltsin to stand by the commitment to India to a large extent, but Yeltsin himself was on a shaky wicket during the systemic disintegration of the Soviet Union. Even when the Supreme Soviet of the Russian Federation, on 21 July 1993 passed a resolution saying that international contracts that come under the Missile Technology Control Regime should have its consent, Glavkosmos stood by its commitment. A media report quoted Glavkosmos: ‘We shall not stop fulfilling our obligations under the contract until there is a government decision to the contrary.’

But we all saw it coming. In May 1993, the ISRO chairman’s office received a call from Dunayev’s secretary conveying that Russia will not be able to honour the cryogenic contract as it was signed. They wanted to make some drastic changes, and that called for some drastic action from us.